



Roles and Responsibilities in the Green Transition

🕒 15 min · Supporting learning resource (LSM)

Module 2 · From Awareness to Action-Skills for Sustainable Business

Unit 2 · Roles and Responsibilities in the Green Transition



Introduction

In the previous unit, we explored what green skills are and why they are important for SMEs. However, understanding sustainability concepts is only the first step. For real change to happen, these concepts must be translated into actions within organisations.

This raises an important question: who is responsible for sustainability in an SME?

In reality, sustainability is not the responsibility of a single person or department. Instead, it is a shared process that involves different roles working together. This is particularly important for SMEs, where organisational structures are often flexible, and employees may take on multiple responsibilities.

This material explains how sustainability is distributed across roles and how each individual contributes to the green transition.

Key concepts explained

Roles in the green transition

In an SME, sustainability involves a variety of roles, each contributing in a different way.

Managers and business owners are responsible for setting priorities and making strategic decisions. For example, they may decide to invest in energy-efficient equipment or adopt more sustainable suppliers.

Employees, on the other hand, are responsible for implementing these decisions in practice. They interact with processes, materials, and equipment on a daily basis. This allows them to identify inefficiencies, such as unnecessary energy use or excessive waste.

Administrative staff also play an important role by organising workflows and supporting digitalisation, which can reduce paper use and improve efficiency.

This shows that sustainability is not limited to one role. Instead, it requires collaboration across the organisation.

Distribution of responsibilities

For sustainability to be effective, responsibilities need to be clearly defined.

Managers typically focus on planning and decision-making. They define goals, allocate resources, and create the conditions for sustainability to be implemented.

Employees focus on execution. For example, an employee may apply energy-saving practices, reduce material waste, or suggest improvements to existing processes.

This creates a shared responsibility model. Sustainability is both:

- top-down, through strategy and leadership
- bottom-up, through daily actions and feedback

If one of these is missing, sustainability efforts may not succeed. For example, a strategy without employee engagement will remain theoretical, while employee initiatives without management support may not be sustained.

The multi-level approach

Sustainability operates at different levels within an organisation.

At the strategic level, decisions are made about priorities and investments. For example, a company may decide to reduce its environmental impact by lowering energy consumption.

At the operational level, these decisions are translated into actions. Employees may adjust how machines are used or introduce new procedures to reduce waste.

At the behavioural level, everyday habits play a crucial role. Simple actions, such as switching off equipment or avoiding unnecessary printing, can have a significant cumulative impact.

These levels are interconnected. A strategic decision will only be effective if it is supported by operational actions and behavioural change.

Key takeaways

Sustainability in SMEs is a shared responsibility that involves all roles within the organisation.

Managers provide direction and resources, while employees implement actions and contribute to improvements.

Clear role definition is essential for avoiding confusion and ensuring effective implementation. Finally, sustainability is not only about strategy but also about behaviour. Everyday actions play a crucial role in achieving long-term results.

Reflection prompts

- What is your role in your organisation's sustainability efforts?
- Are responsibilities for sustainability clearly defined?
- Have you ever identified an inefficiency but not acted on it? Why?
- What is one action you could take to contribute more effectively?

Link to next unit

This unit explored how sustainability responsibilities are distributed across roles within SMEs.

The next unit will focus on how green skills are applied in everyday work situations and how employees can actively contribute to sustainability through practical actions.

Why this matters for SMEs

For SMEs, clearly defined roles and responsibilities are essential for making sustainability practical and achievable.

Without clear roles, sustainability efforts may become fragmented. For example, employees may assume that sustainability is not part of their responsibilities, while managers may expect employees to take initiative without providing guidance.

This can lead to confusion, inefficiency, and missed opportunities.

On the other hand, when roles are clearly defined:

- communication improves
- responsibilities are shared
- actions are coordinated

This helps SMEs reduce costs, improve efficiency, and respond more effectively to environmental requirements.

Practical examples or typical situations

Many SMEs face common situations related to unclear roles. For example, a company may decide to reduce energy consumption, but employees continue using equipment inefficiently because no clear instructions were given.

In another case, employees may identify waste in a process but do not report it because they believe it is not their responsibility.

A more effective approach would be:

- managers clearly communicating expectations
- employees being encouraged to suggest improvements
- responsibilities being integrated into daily tasks

Even simple practices, such as assigning responsibility for monitoring energy use or encouraging digital workflows, can lead to significant improvements.

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